

Worksheet: Demand and Elasticity

ECON 201

Definitions

Percentage change:

$$\% \text{ change} = \frac{100 \times \text{change}}{\text{starting value}}$$

Price elasticity of demand, ε : the percentage change in demand that would occur in response to a 1% increase in price,

$$\varepsilon = - \frac{\% \text{ change in } Q}{\% \text{ change in } P}$$

If price changes by ΔP and demand changes by ΔQ , three other equivalent ways to write it are

$$\varepsilon = - \frac{\Delta Q/Q}{\Delta P/P} = - \frac{P}{Q} \times \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta P} = - \frac{P}{Q} \times \frac{1}{\text{slope}}$$

where the slope of the demand curve is $\Delta P/\Delta Q$.

Demand is **elastic** if ε is greater than 1, and **inelastic** if ε is less than 1.

In Lecture 3, you told us the most you would pay for a day at a Dodgers game. Linearizing your answers gives this demand curve:

$$Q = 90 - 0.3P$$

1. Elasticity from percentage changes

Use percentage changes to find the elasticity of demand for each \$10 price rise below.

Price rises from	Demand, Q	% change in P	% change in Q	Elasticity, ε
\$50 to \$60				
\$100 to \$110				
\$200 to \$210				

At which prices is demand elastic?

2. Elasticity from the formula

Use $\varepsilon = - \frac{P}{Q} \times \frac{\Delta Q}{\Delta P}$ to find the elasticity at the same three prices.

Price, P	\$50	\$100	\$200
Demand, Q			
$\Delta Q/\Delta P$			
Elasticity, ε			

Do you get the same answers as in Activity 1?